



Alternative knowledges in intercultural education and educators as epistemic subjects

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ARTICLE INFO

Keywords:

Intercultural education
The peripheries
The global south
Alternative knowledges
Educators as epistemic subjects

ABSTRACT

The activist underpinnings of intercultural education may be more effective when the theories about the peripheries prioritize self-criticality in conceptualizing and implementing this pedagogy. This warrants examining how epistemic agency is exercised by educators to align the sociologies of intercultural education with the ecologies of their spaces. The aims of this paper are, (a) to unpack the cultural and epistemic formations of teachers' understandings of the premises and objectives of intercultural education and (b) prompt southern epistemic subjects to produce knowledge about intercultural education that accounts for their epistemological positionalities and their consideration of local intimacies, needs and aspirations. This qualitative study uses email interviews with Moroccan EFL teachers to elicit their epistemic input rather than to situate their responses among mainstream literatures. Findings illuminated the complex epistemic processes that educators are engaged in to construct their situated knowledges informed by the intersection of available scholarships, their ontologies and contextual factors. Findings suggest that educators' exercising of intercultural education is problematized by the lack of training which leads to 'improvisation' and the high-abstract rhetorics in literature which may require educators to sustain more efforts in addition to thorny attempt of doing intercultural education otherwise.

1. Introduction

This paper seeks to address the possible limitations of the available knowledges on intercultural education,¹ specifically its epistemological situatedness within Europe and the US (Dervin & R'boul, 2022). For intercultural education and research to realize social activism (Ladegaard & Phipps, 2020), it is essential to unsettle the normative import of Northern theories and perspectives as universal knowledge into the Global South. While It is a refreshing practice to question the knowledges that have been taken for granted, this endeavour also stipulates remedying the colonial mentality, a form of internalized cultural and epistemic inferiority (Nnam, 2007; Grosfoguel, 2007), that may assume the epistemic legitimacy of all insights coming from the Global North (R'boul, 2022a). Within this narrative, encouraging educational policies, scholars and educators within the Global South, defined as 'not just a place (although it is

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¹ While 'intercultural education' is employed throughout this manuscript, there is indeed terminological diversity in designating 'diversity education' across different contexts, literatures and situations. For instance, in other scholarships, 'multicultural education', 'intercultural communication education', 'intercultural in education', 'interculturality in education', 'linguistic diversity', 'social justice' and 'indigenous may be used instead depending on the author's situatedness, the context of the study and the premises of the research (further discussion on this matter is in R'boul & Dervin (2023)).

also that), but a condition (of dispossession)' (Shome, 2019, p. 203), to theorize and exercise intercultural education in their own logics can help visibilize and operationalise alternative epistemic positionalities that focus on local issues, conditions and entanglements. Mainstream theories of intercultural education may need to be epistemologically reconstituted to account for the social, linguistic and cultural specificities of the peripheries, especially when the main objective is social and epistemic justice.

In Europe, policymakers, scholars, and educators continue to stress the importance of interculturality as a nuanced strategy for managing ethnic, cultural and religious diversity (Aman, 2022). However, it has not been established whether this interpretation is what the Global South may 'imagine' and 'need'. While the equity-focused possibilities of intercultural education are undeniable, it remains unclear how they can redress the overlapping systems of privilege/subordination as they are unfolding in the Southern spheres. To further the 'critical' take on intercultural education in the difficult times post-Covid-19 and its aggravation of inequalities (Holmes & Corbett, 2022), it is salient not to confine the study of hierarchies to the sociopolitical boundaries of a particular nation-state. The rationale for this research is, therefore, (a) to propel theorizing and doing intercultural education otherwise by seeking to locate alternative understandings of its premises, logics and goals through educators' situated perceptions, and (b) to make a case for how epistemic agency is exercised by Southern subjects (educators) to align the sociologies of intercultural education with the ecologies of their spaces. Using email interviews with 25 EFL Moroccan teachers, this paper aims to explore educators' knowledge production about intercultural education within the conditions and needs of their local contexts. It seeks to emphasize the locality of knowledge by examining how educators navigate the available knowledges so as to construct situated theorizations and praxis of intercultural education.

2. Morocco's postcolonial positionality and intercultural education in teacher training

Morocco is a North African country that is often situated within the Global South (UNDP, 2004); however, it has been making steady developments across all the vital sectors (e.g., economy, diplomacy, tourism, education, etc.) despite its postcolonial challenges since the end of the French protectorate in 1956. Although French colonialism may have brought a 'modern' system of education, it was an intended policy to perpetuate the subalternity of the local people by teaching them French knowledges, ethics and morals (Zyad, 2021). Following independence, the state mandated the Arabization policy, but it proved unsuccessful in disrupting the significant French impact on the education system in the country (Boutier, 2016). For instance, Moroccan higher education has been functioning through the LMD system (Licence-Master-Doctorat) which is inspired by the French higher education structure (Felahi, 2021). Also, all teachers receive pre-service training in Ecole Normale Supérieure (a school for developing elementary and secondary school teachers in all subjects) and/or Centre Regional des Metiers de l'Education et de la Formation (Regional Center for Education and Training Professions) that are structured according to French models.

In recent years, English and Anglo-sphere educational knowledges, systems and models have been promoted on the basis of their 'decolonial' potential in undoing the French language and perspectives (R'boul & Belhiah, 2023); this attitude is largely due to English's and Anglo-phone countries' lack of colonial legacy in the country (R'boul, 2022b). In particular, in 2023, EFL education has been recently mandated to start in the first year of public middle schools (used to be in the third year while private schools may begin teaching English at the primary level). Yet again, there has been a tendency to foreground and favour Anglophone logics and notions in textbooks and teaching practices in Moroccan ELT (Ait Bouzid, 2016); this may speak of the postcolonial struggles in renouncing colonial-like relations that are reverberated in education. This paper builds on these insights not at the linguistic level per se but the epistemic challenges that impede Morocco's development of an enunciative power to assert its own way of theorizing and doing education. ELT teacher education in Morocco tends to embrace a fairly 'traditional' perspective where there might be little attention to critical discussion on coloniality, epistemic diversity/justice and interculturality (R'boul, 2022c). Pre-service teacher training is a two-semester 7-month program. The courses delivered over the two semesters are:

- Semester 1: 'Teaching Skills'; 'Approaches and Methods'; 'Classroom Management'; 'Planning'; 'Action research'; 'School life'; Education sciences.
- Semester 2: 'Managing the Learning Situation', 'Professional Development/Reflective Teaching'; 'ICTs', 'Testing and Evaluation', 'Material Evaluation and Adaptation', 'Legislation and Ethics', 'Didactic Production and Workshops', 'Micro Teaching and Analysis of Professional Situations'.

This showcases that the teacher education curriculum may not include courses/perspectives on intercultural education which means fewer opportunities for teachers to engage with interculturality, power imbalances, social/epistemic justice and coloniality. Upon asking this study's participants whether they have received any courses/input on intercultural education during their pre and in-service training, they noted that it remains infrequent and insufficient. They have also explained that their knowledge about intercultural education mainly comes from their university studies or own readings. This situation is within EFL education but it may allow for imagining the status of intercultural education in other subjects as well since English remains most associated with interculturality in Morocco given its place as a global language.

2.1. Epistemic agency and locality of knowledge in intercultural education

Dervin and R'boul (2022) call for deconstructing the politics of European intercultural education in scholars' and educators' thinking. Dervin & R'boul explain that instead of recycling the available knowledges in revamped 'critical' forms, scholars can valorise situated narratives that may not necessarily endorse the mainstream. These critiques emphasize how intercultural education is

'predominantly characterised by normative conceptualisations of truth (e.g., characterised by fixed or 'objective' interpretations of language and culture) or hyper-relativist post-truth conceptualisations (e.g., non-essentialist approaches to ICE)' (Simpson, 2022, p. 1) which are largely anchored in western narratives and logics. The dominant 'Western' episteme in intercultural communication education and research reverberates how modern science bestows credibility to northern 'regimes of truth' (R'boul, 2022d). These critiques stipulate transcending conventional epistemic borders to enact a knowledge-production site where silenced Indigenous and Southern epistemologies are seen as legitimate ways of knowing. The development of intercultural education took place in the context of social and historical transformations that were not uniform but were mediated by local conditions (Salgur, 2013). This means that it is not possible to separate knowledge production about intercultural from the social conditions of the Global South. Thus, exercising intercultural education should not re-enact the self-ascribed universality of particular epistemologies and practices (R'boul, 2023).

As intercultural communication is theorized from different ontological and epistemological positions (Ferri, 2018), the decolonial quest for intercultural discourses could only actualize through unsettling assumptions around the universality of western knowledge (Guilherme, 2019) because it impedes epistemologies of the South from attaining visibility. However, it is yet to confront these representation issues within knowledge circulation and consumption and the role of epistemic violence in speaking for 'the other' (Ferri, 2022). Moreover, the new socio-cultural, political and economic rationales of globalisation, Europeanisation and modernisation may have constrained the centrality of the nation-state. That is, global socio-political and economic developments have enabled 'supranational institutions, functioning across nation states rather than within them, to perform many state functions with regards to education policy development and implementation' (Hajisoteriou & Angelides, 2016, p. 1). Dervin (2023) explained that supranational institutions cannot be assumed to produce neutral and universal knowledge, especially since one cannot readily support a supposedly neutral (researcher's) position who can generate 'objective knowledge' about the 'Other' (de Sousa Santos, 2007; Mignolo, 2021). Dervin (2023) suggests teaching for diversity through more politicized and critical theories so as to move beyond mere 'facts' and 'catering'; For instance, teachers may employ postcolonial theory, critical race theory and other theoretical perspectives that are relevant to their contexts to realize educational transformation.

Intercultural education's potential for unsettling power structures may be compromised when the theories of the 'intercultural' are informed by the Centre-western perspectives of culture, Self and the Other (Welikala, 2021). Non-Western cultural realities may have been falsely defined by the Western cognitive empire which is probably the 'penalty' that comes with being ontologically and ecologically different (Holliday & Macdonald, 2020). A serious epistemological consequence here is 'Hermeneutical Injustice' (Fricker, 2007) which argues that due to historical hierarchies and silences of some groups of people from constructing knowledge about themselves, their experiences are not well understood by them and/or others. The lack of available knowledge makes 'their experiences unfit for any concepts or analysis known to them or the others. Therefore, persons who have been historically excluded continue to struggle to interpret their ontologies and ecologies' (R'boul, 2022e, pp. 1154–1155). Overall, this section contributes to the paper's logics by elaborating on how Global knowledge production is characterized by an epistemic hierarchy within which local knowledges are systematically excluded and invalidated (Demeter, 2020). We are asking how relevant the current theorizations and practices of intercultural education may be for the Global South from the perspectives of educators. To avoid reproducing essentialist epistemologies of the South, we also appeal for critical reflection on how Southern contexts and ways of knowing may be represented as homogenous entities denying the specificities of situated perspectives (Ndlovu-Gatsheni, 2021). What is at stake is an epistemic priority of excluded knowledges, which would, in turn, enable inter-epistemic dialogues aimed at creating a plural ecology of knowledges (Sugiharto, 2021).

2.2. Southern educators as epistemic subjects

While some voices may defend a role for teachers that is limited to facilitation, this paper joins the discourses that eschew this rather passive understanding of the role of teachers and, thus, defends a perception of educators as critical mediators of knowledge. The role of teachers as mediators of knowledge is informed by the debates in epistemology about knowledge and truth. Also, their agency as sociocultural critics, with a similar function as art critics, stems from debates around knowledge, values and the politics of curriculum design (Mason, 2000). The main premise is, therefore, researching educators' knowledge production is important because it allows for exploring educators as both the knowing subject and the acting subject.

Imperiale (2021) drew upon a research project on intercultural language education conducted online between 2014 and 2017 with people living in the Gaza Strip (Palestine). Since the Gaza Strip has been under blockade since 2007, people are not allowed to travel in and out freely. This situation carries a substantial impact on educators' and scholars' intellectual labour since they reflect on intercultural competence from a context of protracted crisis and forced immobility. The researcher investigated pre-service and in-service English teachers' understandings of intercultural competence and how these educators seek to develop students' intercultural communicative competence (ICC) in their classrooms in the Gaza Strip; a sphere where neither teachers nor students may have had the opportunity to travel abroad or experienced a face-to-face intercultural encounter (a context that implies some similarities to the Moroccan context and other spheres in the Global South). Imperiale stressed that frameworks for intercultural education and ICC should 'capture non-movement and the lack of face-to-face intercultural encounters as 'agentic' in definitions of interculturality...ICC should be conceptualised in terms of the actual freedoms and opportunities that individuals have to develop and nurture it' (p. 22). This denotes that educators' positionalities could shape their imaginations in terms of receiving, understanding and recycling knowledges on intercultural education depending on the linguistic, cultural and epistemic systems framing social reality within their local contexts.

Education to accommodate students' diversity is given 'different institutional meanings in different states according to the national and political culture' (Hajisoteriou, 2013, p. 107). In Latin America, intercultural education seeks to valorise the cultural, ethnic, and

linguistic diversity of its citizens, and to foreground the activist attempts to dismantle the oppressive dynamics with such diversity, particularly that of Indigenous and Afro-descendant peoples. While discourses of intercultural education often reference such peoples as their main beneficiaries, too few studies researching the professional development of educators recognize and propel 'the importance of Indigenous scholarship, pedagogies and methodologies themselves as resources for the advancement of the theory and practice of intercultural education' (Cortina & Earl, 2020, p. 1). It is indeed useful to advance more locality and alignment of these theories by assigning more epistemic vitality to educators to build on the available understandings to construct more nuanced and contextualized knowledges. For example, teachers' conceptualizations of diversity could index their socializations and their perceptions of their spheres rather than a universal conception that captures ontological multiplicity with regard to race, ethnicity, culture and language in general terms.

Considering the substantial role teachers play in implementing globalised policies for intercultural education, Hajisoteriou and Angelides (2016) probed into the ways in which Cypriot teachers' definitions of intercultural education influence their teaching and their agency in promoting the inclusion of immigrant students. Most of the participant teachers seemed to confuse language, understandings of diversity and intercultural education. Two interdependent but also contrasting sub-themes emerged: the monocultural approach (cultural-deficit perspective) and the multicultural approach (cultural-celebration perspective). These findings imply that knowledge construction could interweave contrasting understandings of diversity and intercultural education that may be anchored in personal epistemologies while making sense of and interpreting sociocultural complexities and the premises of intercultural education. We need to acknowledge potential fragmentations in the sense that educators' understandings involve varied and fragmented knowledges rather than signs of confusion and inconsistency. These narratives could be seen as evidence of not only the intricacies inherent in navigating the literature but also educators' epistemic agency and capacities in (re)moulding, (un)learning and (re) thinking theories and praxis in relation to the ecological conditions of their classrooms and wider context.

Intercultural teacherhood may encompass various nuanced perspectives that are shaped by the dominant conceptions of cultural diversity, education, knowledge and ecology in a given space. For instance, López and Morales (2021) maintain that the impacts of colonialism and anti-colonialism need to be explored with reference to not only the institutional structures and geopolitical frameworks of the disparate regions but also educators' thinking; they clarify that being globally and interculturally competent in Chile may entail different attributes than being globally and interculturally competent in the United States. Personal knowledge production navigating global and local knowledges may assist teachers in dealing with the discomfort and ambivalence often experienced while teaching in diverse schools and coping with changing contextual conditions (Zembylas, 2010). This research argues that examining educators' knowledge generation allows for inspecting the type of indexes and parameters by which they assign credibility and validity to different knowledges and perspectives; this would also help develop a deeper understanding into educators' epistemologies by researching (a) their intellectual/cognitive dynamics in making informed choices and (b) how pedagogical and practical knowledge about intercultural education could be attained and, ultimately, selectively used in their classrooms.

3. Methodology

3.1. Research design

This paper builds on the epistemological rationales that (a) intercultural education is open to re-interpretation, re-theorizing and re-exercising and (b) it is a fundamental *priori* in activist and decentering educational theories to ascertain the alignment of the intercultural education's premises with the sociocultural and sociopolitical conditions of the context where teaching is taking place. Taking these insights into account, the aims are, therefore, (a) to unpack the cultural and epistemic formations of teachers' understandings of the rationales, complexities and objectives of intercultural education in Morocco as a peripheral Southern country that is under-researched in mainstream literature, (b) prompt southern epistemic subjects to produce knowledge about intercultural education that is underpinned by their own epistemological positionalities and their consideration of local intimacies, needs and aspirations and (c) pose and answer questions around parameters of epistemic validity of certain educational theories in the peripheries and how locality of knowledge is an essential factor in ensuring depth and nuance in teaching praxis. To this end, the study addresses the following research questions:

- A. What are teachers' discourses in making sense of intercultural education and its inherent premises?
- B. What contextualizations of intercultural education may teachers develop for addressing adamant issues in their local contexts?

This study seeks to function within the meeting/intersection of the available theories on intercultural education and teachers' knowledges and perceptions. Educators in the Global South may find it hard to assert the legitimacy of their own theories and praxis both within their contexts and beyond; that is why the design of the study was meant to foreground the intellectual agency of teachers as producers of theoretical and pedagogical knowledge rather than receivers and implementers of imported insights. Data analysis was not conducted based on pre-established parameters, but rather as an open-ended process intended to accentuate emergent perspectives from teachers' knowledge construction.

Email interviews were mediated through pre-constructed prompts in the form of reflective questions. The prompts were constructed to elicit teachers' epistemic input rather than to situate their responses among mainstream literatures. Questions included defining intercultural education within the Moroccan context, elaborating on rationales for embracing this pedagogical framework, and discussing objectives, complexities, and barriers within their spheres as well as their both actual classroom praxis and perspective of the effective implementations of intercultural education (Appendix A). Questions targeted grounding teachers' intellectual

productions within their geopolitical locations and the contextual factors that may have shaped their understanding and exercising of intercultural education.

3.2. Research participants

25 EFL high school teachers (14 male, 11 female) from eight public schools across Morocco took part in the email interviews. There are no significant differences across these schools that may have influenced the data. All schools were public and adopted the same curriculum, materials and teaching-learning guidelines mandated by the Ministry of Education. While there are no strict requirements on the number of respondents in qualitative interviews, (Creswell & Creswell, 2018) estimated that between 10 and 50 participants may be sufficient depending on the research's orientation, focus, questions and objectives. Also, Dworkin (2012) clarified that most researchers tend to suggest sample sizes of 5 to 50. Given the nature of interview prompts that would generate extended and detailed responses, 25 participants is a reasonable sample because (a) it ensures that there is a variety of perspectives underpinned by different beliefs and logics and which represents the diversity of EFL teachers in Morocco, (b) it generates an amount of data that is sufficient to answer the research questions (data saturation), and (c) the amount of data produced is feasible and can be, thus, effectively analyzed by the researcher.

EFL teachers were purposely involved in this research since they were the most exposed to the literature and debates on intercultural education given (a) the extensive scholarships produced on interculturality and English as the main linguistic code mediating intercultural encounters and (b) teachers' educational backgrounds as they have had courses on intercultural communication and education throughout their BA, MA and PhD studies. This study employed purposive sampling as the population was selected in a non-random manner. Researchers used expert knowledge of the population to determine the essential characteristics to be represented in the sample. The participants were teachers who (a) have received some input on intercultural education either throughout their studies or training, (b) have had at least 3 years of teaching experience to draw on their classroom praxis in processing the phenomenon under investigation and (b) represent a cross-section of EFL teachers who went through the official channels for becoming a certified in-service high school teacher in Morocco. All teachers were holders of a B.A., master's degree and/or PhD in cross-cultural communication, cultural studies, linguistics, literary studies, or ELT. All participants have received pre-service teacher training at either *Ecole Normale Supérieure* (a school devoted to preparing elementary and secondary school teachers in all subjects) or at *Centre Régional des Métiers de l'Éducation et de la Formation* (Regional Center for Education and Training Professions). Participants' teaching experience ranged from 3 to 25 years. All teachers participated voluntarily upon invitation.

3.3. Data collection

Due to the participants' preferences and the research's focus on exploring teachers' knowledge construction, email interviews were employed to provide participants with a substantial amount of time to (a) reflect on the questions and (b) engage in a critical introspection-retrospection process of knowledge generation (Pell et al., 2020) that would produce rich and informative accounts (James, 2007) and ensure the generation of considerable and relevant qualitative data (McCoyd & Kerson, 2006). Email interviews are "a qualitative research method where information is repeatedly exchanged online between researcher and participant within a particular timeframe" (Ratislavová & Ratislav, 2014). In this method, the respondents are asked to engage with a series of open-ended questions; then, researchers send reflective follow-up questions that address certain aspects of interest to prompt the production of relevant and significant responses. The email threads formed between the researchers and respondents reaffirm the generative process involved in this method. This again asserts the practical utility and epistemic suitability of email interviews in qualitative research (Hawkins, 2018).

Electronic research methods are increasingly embraced as a valid way of generating qualitative data (O'Connor & Madge, 2017), and researchers with relevant experience continue to emphasize these methods' equivalence to traditional in-person methods (Dahlin, 2021). The quality of data generated by electronic research methods is not different from data generated by more traditional methods; also, it has been argued that these methods may even improve the more traditional research methods (Braun et al., 2017). While classroom observations may be an effective method in capturing educators' praxis, this paper focuses on educators' knowledge negotiation and production which may be better explored through educators' narratives and discourses (through interviews) as a generative epistemic process interweaving the prompts and carefully crafted responses. Also, using observations would entail unpacking (in)consistencies between educators' beliefs and their praxes which is indeed an interesting dimension but would require a separate paper where a relevant theoretical framework and analytical lens are employed. Interviews are useful in theory construction and development which is a fundamental rationale and objective of this research.

Participants' consent was procured after they were informed of the study's objectives as well as all the steps of the research process including how data will be collected and used. Participants were also notified that their identities and responses were processed in privacy throughout the recruitment and dissemination stages according to the university's Data Protection Policy. To ascertain confidentiality, participants were not asked to share their names. Randomly assigned numbers were generated to identify participants; high school teachers are referred to as HT1, HT2, etc. throughout data collection and the dissemination of the findings. Interviews were conducted in English for three main reasons: (a) educators indicated their preference to use English given their familiarity with the notions, concepts and theories produced in English-speaking literature, (b) the use of English may prompt educators to reflect on their agency in speaking the language (e.g., importers of knowledge associated with the Anglo-sphere) and engage in a reflexive knowledge production that recognizes the potential incongruences between attempting to foreground local perspectives and using a foreign language to do so, and (c) conducting interviews in English was for the sake of convenience since there would be no need for translation

which may run the risk of inaccurately representing participants' narratives.

3.4. Data analysis

Thematic analysis (Braun & Clarke, 2021) was used as an analytic qualitative process to code and categorize responses into recurring themes and subthemes which would be later designated as potential lines of thought in teachers' knowledge production around intercultural education. The aim was to note patterns and themes from the coded texts to construct a structured compendium of codes that describe how codes interrelate. Coding categories often form a hierarchy of categories. Researchers applied the recursive six-phase process for thematic analysis explained by Clarke and Braun (2014). Researchers also considered the guidelines in the form of twenty critical questions advanced by Braun and Clarke (2021) to promote reflexive engagement and high(er) standards in thematic analysis research.

Numerous pages of email interview data were generated. Data were qualitatively analyzed using QDA Miner software to ensure structure and organization. At first, the responses were entered into the software, and then the relevant segments were assembled under different labels to form codes. The final step of thematic analysis was highlighting the most salient and recurrent 'constellations' of meanings present in participants' statements. Categories were labelled in keeping with their thematic congruence to generate themes and subthemes. The themes are presented and discussed in a hierarchical structure in terms of recurrence, relevance and importance to the research objectives and questions. Selected extracts from email interview data are featured for illustration.

4. Findings

4.1. Conceptualisations of intercultural education

The majority of participants defined intercultural education in ways that reiterate the common understandings of interculturality within education that tend to emphasize respect, democracy and co-existence as core elements of reconciling differences among various cultures, knowledges and ontologies (HT1, HT3, HT4, HT6, HT13, HT14, HT15, HT16, HT17, HT19, HT21, HT22, HT23 and HT24). While there have been slight variations in stressing the 'local', 'global' and 'in-between', teachers' discourses established overt warrants around cultural diversity and how 'reconciliation' among cultures regardless of the differences is possible by means of moulding students' attitudes by supplying cultural knowledge about the other. Teachers further pointed out the exigency of developing students' intercultural awareness (HT3) and contributing to their epistemic capacities in constructing a 'sophisticated knowledge about the others' ways of life, behaviours and backgrounds' (HT13). Moreover, the notions of 'foreign' and 'global' cultures were often included in the participants' rhetorics as they highlighted the provision of input on foreign cultures. For instance, HT14 explained that intercultural education relates to how 'some aspects of foreign cultures are included in and covered by the Moroccan educational system'. Further narratives with similar gist are as follows:

'Intercultural education is the education that includes cross-cultural beliefs, attitudes and values that are not limited to only one culture, but to a wide variety of cultures' (HT17)

'I understand intercultural education as a type of teaching approach that considers the diversity of local and global cultures during the teaching/learning process' (HT19)

Some participants oriented intercultural education to account for the local cultural specificities characterizing its main premise as a pedagogical intervention that manages cultural diversity within Morocco (HT2, HT5, HT10, HT12 and HT20). HT2 argued that 'intercultural education is about taking into consideration the diversity of cultures inside the classroom...providing every learner with cultural knowledge will enable them to respect and understand the varieties and differences that exist among individuals', but they further maintained that intercultural education is about 'preserving the cultural identity of the learner' in what could be the case of a context-bound and serving pedagogy. A similar stance was delivered by HT18 who noted that intercultural education in Morocco is 'the quality of respecting and integrating students' cultural identity in the process of teaching and learning'. Further statements underscored the exigency of accommodating the diversities within the classroom as representations of cultural capital in the country:

'In the context of Morocco, intercultural education is a pedagogical approach and an ongoing process that aims at establishing co-existence and tolerance between students holding different backgrounds inside their classrooms as representatives of the Moroccan multicultural society' (HT5)

'Morocco as a country is distinguished by its multilingualism and cultural diversity, it is endowed with a rich and diverse cultural heritage resulting from the marriage of traditions, habits and customs of different cultures and civilizations' (HT12)

Interestingly, two participants made some references to the asymmetries within and among cultures (HT7 and HT8). HT7 asserted that while 'intercultural education in Morocco is a type of education where diverse cultures are taken into account in designing curriculums and syllabi', it is important to shed light on how 'not all cultures of the world are equal which also the case for the different cultures found in Morocco'; these social realities, as framed by the participant, may require customizing and accommodating intercultural education to make sense of linguistic, cultural and epistemic hierarchies and to ultimately navigate the plurality of cultural ontologies without re-enacting and reproducing inequalities. HT8 indicated that intercultural education within the sociocultural and sociopolitical particularities of Morocco is 'a form of instruction that trains students to understand, respect, and accept to get in contact with different cultures'; however, intercultural education needs to reverberate a profound engagement with the 'dizzying diversity' of the country and how 'Its historical trajectory defines its modern day society and characterizes its linguistic environment' that there are 'four major mutually unintelligible languages are being used' which may cogently suggest that 'Morocco was never homogeneous neither linguistically nor culturally, that is why the need for nuanced intercultural education is of paramount importance'.

4.2. Practising intercultural education

A large number of participants confirmed that they exercise intercultural education (HT1, HT2, HT3, HT4, HT7, HT8, HT10, HT12, HT14, HT15, HT16, HT18, HT19, HT20 and HT22). Teachers' discourses drew on various epistemic modalities and semiotic resources that they consider to be culturally significant and would ascertain a certain level of intercultural awareness which was featured as a principal epistemic embedment. Several participants stressed a teaching method that centres cultural differences as a line of analysis and thought that would illuminate interculturality by constructing the understanding that these differences are characteristic features of particular cultures (HT2, HT3, HT14, HT18, HT20 and HT22). It could be inferred that, for participants, differences were the fundamental rationales for making (inter)culturality relevant. For instance, HT2 noted that by providing examples that belong to different cultural backgrounds, they try to 'raise the learners' awareness concerning the cultural differences and the importance of respect, tolerance and acceptance'. HT18 pointed out that they seek to 'raise students' awareness towards the cultural differences that exist within the Moroccan context and those between Moroccan culture and foreign cultures' which would ultimately 'show the necessity of embracing and accepting each other's differences' (HT3). Capitalizing on differences as an epistemic gateway to process and navigate various cultures is supplemented by the endeavour of comparing them 'with our Moroccan culture' (HT14 and HT22).

Furthermore, some participants focalized local cultures as the main point of departure in practising intercultural education (HT1, HT7, HT12, and HT16). They particularly accentuated the weightiness of 'investing any available cultural background bearing in mind the multitude of learners' ways of thinking' as a potentially inviting pedagogical attempt to prompt students to 'relate to themselves, either with concrete and/or abstract examples' (HT1). These narratives may have been informed by a critical grasp of the unequal dynamics among cultures which could explain the focus on local languages, cultures and identities as a primary source of conceptualizing interculturality and locating oneself among others. This assumption is reflected more noticeably in HT12's rhetorics who expressed how they aim at 'building relationships with my students, approaching them with curiosity and helping them grow their self-confidence in showing their identity and in accepting other students' backgrounds and ideology'. More statements that exhibit similar sentiments include:

'Mainly by conducting activities that encourage learners to consider their culture and the other cultures by knowing more about their own culture and reflecting on it' (HT7)

'I implement it to bring different students who happen to be from different backgrounds, into embracing each other's ideas, language, and cultural aspects' (HT16)

On the other hand, several participants reported that they do not implement intercultural education due to a wide range of contextual factors including the lack of pre-service training (HT6 and HT17), some administrative pressure to teach in certain ways (HT9 and HT21), students' linguistic competence (HT11), class size (HT23) and the perceived necessity of teaching grammar (HT24). HT13 contended that they might be exercising intercultural education but the type of input and geographical focus of the materials may not qualify as a pedagogy of interculturality; they clarified that 'information on other cultures is mostly the American one in our textbooks; we can compare things between the two societies...since they know a lot of things about America, I believe that this is not enough frankly speaking'. Also, HT5 shared how they might inadvertently be employing intercultural education 'through assigning reading texts and activities that target different cultures and by highlighting the importance of respecting each other's difference'.

4.3. Complexities/Barriers to exercising intercultural education

Several teachers noted that the lack of training and the outdated syllabi and textbooks were the main reasons hindering the implementation of intercultural education (HT3, HT5, HT8, HT15, HT19, HT20, HT21, HT22, HT23 and HT24). HT3 emphasized that 'the negligence of this significant topic during educational internships, may create some kind of difficulty while implementing it'. HT5 illustrated that 'the foremost challenge is the lack of training in intercultural education and the outdated syllabi that need a total reform as well as the lack of national and international exchange programs'. Also, HT23 stated that 'the things that hinder the implementation of intercultural education have to do with outdated materials and lack of training'.

A number of participants assigned the teacher the highest agency for not practising intercultural education (HT1, HT4, HT7, HT9, HT10, HT14, HT17 and HT18); the rhetorics here were not about recognizing how teachers are placed within the nexus of competing interests and ideologies, but rather holding them as the main actor affecting how interculturality in education is either reinforced or neglected. For instance, HT7 pointed out teachers' lack of intercultural competence while HT9 and HT10 reaffirmed that exercising intercultural education stipulates having teachers who are highly knowledgeable about many cultural concepts suggesting that some educators may not be familiar with the notions that tend to comprise the focal elements in interculturality within education. A more assertive stance was delivered by HT18 who claimed that 'teachers may not be aware of the importance of integrating students' cultural identity in the process of teaching and learning and some educators may tend to be culturally biased'. Within the same logic, HT14 maintained that 'many teachers and students seem to be conservatives, and consider dealing with foreign cultures as a threat to their Moroccan culture'. HT1 attributed teachers' tendency not to implement intercultural education to 'insufficient knowledge' which is largely due to the officials' focus on other matters such as content, grammar and preparing for exams; an assumption that was supported by HT4 and HT17 as well. HT1 and HT14 further explicated that:

'the teacher's lack of formation and/or educational attainment. By this, we mean that the government itself failed, and still in a way or another, to form competent teachers that can, both, tolerate their students' cultural diversity; let alone effectively communicating with them'

Few participants indicated that students may display some unwillingness and push back to discuss/examine interculturality due to the pre-conceived notions and the type of understandings that have been previously inculcated in their minds and psyches (HT2, HT6,

HT9, HT11, HT13, and HT16). Participants stressed that students as epistemic subjects rely on the ideologies that have been nurtured within their communities since the possibility of placing oneself among different others entails a range of 'perils' that endanger their own situated beliefs, perspectives and knowledges. For example, HT6 stated that 'the one barrier that could stand in the way of achieving an intercultural education is the background hateful and disdainful ideas that are integrated into students' minds about other cultures'. Further statements with similar narratives include:

'students might be hesitant to engage in the Intercultural educational process due to their past judgements and/or presumptions they picked up from their social circles' (HT9)

'the barriers that might happen while implementing intercultural education are finding difficulty with accepting others' identities, religions and individual choices. Also, the discomfort of students if they find something offensive to their own traditions or religion' (HT11)

5. Discussion and conclusion: reflecting on educators as intellectuals

Some participants reported employing differences as an epistemological compass to make sense of interculturality and to implement intercultural education; while this pedagogical endeavour may appear legitimate given the substantial literature on cultural indexes and differences, it could re-enact and re-produce linguistic, cultural and epistemic hierarchies since these disparities are represented as lenses for explaining some individuals' practices and knowledges. It could be argued that these differences supply a proximate understanding of cultures but it essentially implies the naturalization of hierarchies as a normal development of societies' divergent ontologies and epistemologies. Instead of focalizing differences as a neutral and systematic exposition of cultures, educators are encouraged to take a more complex approach in deconstructing the political construction of differences, rather than differences per se (Dervin & Simpson, 2021). Also, the prevalence of this pedagogical philosophy may be due to teacher education (Hinojosa Pareja & López, 2018) or the lack of it which assigns educators' the complicated task of teaching interculturality by 'improvising' (Tan et al., 2022) and possibly resorting to any theories accessible to them that they perceive to be commensurate with the cognitive/intellectual development of their students. Insufficient training and the process of navigating interculturality could precipitate reducing the 'intercultural' to a set of easily digestible chunks of factual knowledge that are presumably grounded in stereotypes and considerable exercising of overgeneralization. The focus on differences may further intensify the dichotomies of 'US' and 'THEM' as epistemologies of inequalities that underscore the notion of uncrossable cultural boundaries (Holliday, 2016).

Educators' discourses in this study have been consistent with the mainstream literature which could entail neither any positive nor negative connotation/outcome, but it may suggest the difficulty of epistemological delinking from the very theories that educators have been taught as they were the first knowledges provided to them to comprehend interculturality; this assumption could be substantiated by my own autoethnographic accounts as a researcher (during my doctoral research) and student who was exposed to interculturality-related courses in Moroccan high schools and universities. Some teachers/professors shared how interculturality is usually exclusively included in English-related syllabi as, for curriculum designers, English as a linguistic pattern is most associated with intercultural encounters. They further noted how they were unprepared for this task and were 'burdened' to make intellectually-arduous decisions on what and how to teach interculturality. They explained that due to the class size and the primacy of exams for the administration and students, they had recourse to any materials that were open-access and readily available to them which may often centre differences as an epistemological strategy for processing and navigating interculturality. That is why future research on teaching interculturality in the Global South needs to involve investigating teachers' sense of their intercultural teacherhood and the potential illegitimacy that may have experienced under the rubrics of the various epistemological and professional factors. A further study is required to uncover teachers' objectives in teaching interculturality and whether it is dictated or co-negotiated in a top-down process.

A number of participants noted that they don't implement intercultural education; this perception could be grounded in the understanding that they feel that they do not explicitly exercise any equity-based pedagogical framework that resembles the principles associated with intercultural education in the mainstream literature. We could be wondering whether these teachers would still report 'not' exercising intercultural education when the underlying theories, premises and practices of intercultural education are anchored in alternative knowledges. It is important to take into account how teachers may be navigating/appraising their situated perspectives and classroom decisions against the established mainstream scholarships. That is, the epistemic and practical proximity between their philosophies and practices and the dominant knowledges could be fundamental factors in shaping their assessment of their implementations of intercultural education in terms of orientation and effectiveness. Again, beliefs and practices are not always consistent and the very reasons for these inconsistencies are worthwhile. This could be referred to as 'locus of praxis' which captures how educators process the available literature to develop their own theories which are ultimately translated into practices.

Southern scholars have long argued for visibilizing diverse ways of knowing so as to unsettle the hegemony of Euro-modernist epistemologies that have continuously reincarnated themselves into orthodoxy within the academy. Euro-modernist epistemologies start from positivist 'scientific' principles that ignore the diversity of ways of reading and interpreting social experience as they represent subjective understandings about what constitutes original and legitimate knowledge (Monceri, 2022). That is, helping educators to reaffirm their own epistemic labour and informed choices would bring diverse ontological and cultural traditions to mediate pathways for generating interconnected forms of knowledge that transcend the limits of mono-epistemic ways of seeing feeling and knowing; such as rationale supports the decentering endeavours for cognitive justice in education and training which is inseparable from the broader struggle for global social justice (Ndhlovu & Kelly, 2020). However, despite the advertised 'decentering' potency of decolonial and 'otherwise' endeavours within intercultural education, we need to exercise caution with how 'the otherwise's' alternative essence is not fulfilled as long as the same perspectives are being remoulded with the 'mainstream' speaking the 'otherwise' [because] marginalised and overshadowed perspectives are essential in theorising a genuine 'otherwise' (R'boul, 2022f, p. 222).

Another problematic here is how decolonial discourses may tend to sermonize with high-abstract rhetorics which may require educators to sustain more efforts in addition to the pedagogical complexities and contextual factors (class size, time constraints, students' linguistic competence...).

Although the 'critical' turn in interculturality is well-recognized, it may not have managed to thwart the epistemic reliance on White/Western frameworks, precipitating the dismissal of subaltern knowledges and ontologies. Problematizing notions of interculturality derived from the centre (the global North) needs to be predicated upon the development of more locally constructed theories, pedagogies, and materials (Dervin & Jacobsson, 2022; Holmes & MacDonald, 2020). The Glocality of knowledge in intercultural education needs to be premised upon the very assumption that studying and making use of other people's knowledges does not nullify knowing one's own knowledge (de Sousa Santos, 2007). The Glocality of knowledge entails making sense of and navigating various epistemic resources. Educators may be able to exercise transknowledging by transcending, working through and manipulating the cognitive boundaries whose legitimacy is contingent on the aggrandisement of asymmetries, differences, and the difficulty of establishing convergent epistemological stances.

Again, accounting for local specificities is complicated by the thorny and controversial issue of teaching (and learning) interculturality in ways that reflect interpretations of the notion from critical and reflexive perspectives when introduced to students (Dervin, Yuan & Sude, 2022). This creates a compelling rationale for examining how educators develop their understandings functioning through and within various perspectives of principal notions in intercultural education, e.g. 'multiculturalism', 'interculturality' and the 'transcultural' as negotiated in different north-south conceptual frameworks (Guilherme & Dietz, 2015; Baker, 2021). By accentuating southern subjects' (educators) knowledge construction, this paper is informed by the decolonial critique that has stressed the exigency of looking inward for change rather than passively awaiting guidance from the Global North (de Sousa Santos, 2021). Acting upon this thesis to commence from the inside to sustain the locality of knowledge is important since the available decentering discourses may have '(a) sustained exclusion while claiming to be inclusive; (b) maintained the status quo while claiming to be radical; and (c) reinscribed Westerncentrism while claiming to decolonize' (Moosavi, 2022, p. 1).

It is essential to pay attention to teachers' discomfort and its pedagogical implications in multicultural and intercultural teacher education (Zembylas & Papamichael, 2017). In particular, English language teachers (same in this study) may be asked to make use of intercultural education and/or to teach intercultural communication although they do not specialize in this complex field. While teacher education programs in some southern countries may not include a specific course on 'intercultural education', teachers' epistemic beliefs and knowledge construction dynamics may have consequences for their pedagogical work (Lammasaari et al., 2021). This 'improvised' Intercultural Teacherhood has a major impact not only on their sense of legitimacy but also on their investment in constructing knowledge in order to fill the epistemic gaps in how to teach the subject matter they have at hand (Tan et al., 2022). Personal epistemology is fundamental to intellectual development and education since epistemological understanding has crucial implications for learning including the nature of knowledge to be consumed, used and taught (Hofer, 2008). However, adopting and implementing glocal policies for intercultural education can be challenging when teachers are placed at the heart of the production and promotion of alternative understandings of intercultural education that are informed by a myriad of resources which, in turn, could be contributing to the local policies development for intercultural education.

We may opt for analyzing educators' knowledge production by framing what we think of their narratives as attestations of the overwhelming influence of contextual factors (education, professional development and experience). We may also appeal to educators' epistemological situatedness by emphasising their locus of enunciation which refers to 'the geo-political and body-political location of the subject that speaks' (p. 6). Educators' locus of enunciation would generate profound insights into the dynamics through which knowledges are perceived, recycled, revised and presented. It could also assist in shedding light on the intersection of their own beliefs, the literature and contextual factors. While examining educators' knowledge production is interesting, it remains critical to probe into their knowledge construction processes which are not independent of the epistemological input they have received either through scholarships, academic studies and/or teacher education programs. On the one hand, educators' knowledges is conditioned by a myriad of factors and it has to be analyzed in ways that pay attention to their ontologies (as human beings perceiving existence in particular ways), epistemic subjects (individuals with cognitive capacities), implementers (individuals with skills of turning knowledge into practical applications) and contextual agents (individuals that are trying to balance theory, practice and context).

CRedit authorship contribution statement

Hamza R'boul: Writing – review & editing, Writing – original draft, Validation, Resources, Methodology, Investigation, Formal analysis, Data curation, Conceptualization.

Supplementary materials

Supplementary material associated with this article can be found, in the online version, at [doi:10.1016/j.ijer.2024.102391](https://doi.org/10.1016/j.ijer.2024.102391).

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